

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



Street vendor Carlos Garcia uses tongs to bag steaming tamales at the family's tamale cart along 26th Street in Chicago's Little Village on Saturday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Labor rift could trip up budget

Only one union has cheered Johnson's \$16.6B plan, giving him less leverage

By Alice Yin and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

As Mayor Brandon Johnson has shaken hands in church pews and given booming speeches in school auditoriums while selling his 2026 budget plan directly to Chicagoans, one color has been notably muted among his supporters: purple. That's the signature hue of the Service Employees International Union, whose local affiliates were Johnson's second-biggest labor backer in his 2023 election. Instead, the self-styled "most pro-worker mayor" in Chicago's history has only seen one union vociferously cheer his \$16.6 billion proposal, despite his hard line against layoffs: the red-shirted Chicago Teachers Union.

It's a sign of the times after a "fissure" between the once-close SEIU and CTU has grown into a full-blown "fracture," said Ald. Desmon Yancy, a freshman progressive who previously served in SEIU leadership.

And the labor fight has implications for the whole city. Billions of dollars in property taxes and other money from residents' pockets are in play as Johnson tries to get aldermen to approve his spending plan. With some unions working against him or staying on the sidelines, he has less political firepower and could be forced to compromise his progressive vision in ways big and small in exchange for votes.

Turn to Labor, Page 4

After blitz, immigrants left with trauma, hope

'We are anxious and worried': Communities in pain as they start coming back to life

By Laura Rodríguez Presa and Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

Inside a modest second-floor apartment on Chicago's Southwest Side, three children went without sleep waiting for their mom to finally come home.

Their dad, with a family friend, had driven through the night to get her. More than five hours in the dark to pick her up from the dingy jail in rural Indiana, five hours more on the way back. They arrived home just as the sky began to lighten that early Tuesday morning.

When Patricia Quishpe stepped out, her kids rushed into the cold morning air to wrap her in their arms. Her *hijos*. The word she had cried when the Ecuadorian mother of three was arrested by Border Patrol agents at the Swap-O-Rama flea market in mid-October, during President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown dubbed Operation Midway Blitz.

"I feel blessed," Quishpe told the Tribune last week about her release. Quishpe, her husband and their children all have pending asylum cases, and she has a work permit. The experience of her

arrest is too painful to talk about, she said.

As U.S. Border Patrol chief Gregory Bovino and his agents move on to other cities, most recently sweeping through North Carolina, those affected by the blitz across Chicago and its suburbs are facing a new normal in its aftermath. Thousands of families are now living with trauma and disruption, whether they've been reunited like Quishpe, have loved ones still detained or feel their loss from deportation. Throughout the Latino communities of Pilsen and Little Village, neighborhood restaurants and bars that

generations of immigrants have filled daily are cautiously coming back to life after weeks of fear and empty streets.

While the subsequent end of Operation Midway Blitz has drawn a sense of relief for some, the reality facing the city and its suburbs is far more complicated. A federal appeals court Thursday temporarily halted the release on bond of hundreds of immigrants arrested during the two-month operation, dashing the hopes of families who had looked forward to possibly having their loved ones

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Foreign student enrollment declines

Many universities in Illinois see drops after policy change

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

International enrollment dropped at nearly two dozen Illinois universities this fall, with some seeing dramatic declines after the Trump administration tightened student visa policies.

A Tribune analysis of 27 of the state's largest universities found that foreign enrollment dipped at all but four institutions, including the University of Chicago and a handful of liberal arts colleges.

The data shows the sweeping scope of President Donald Trump's efforts to reshape higher education: While the decline in international enrollment hit large, urban schools such as DePaul University, it also reached rural colleges downstate, enrolling just a few thousand students.

Many institutions are feeling the pinch. DePaul, which saw a 62% drop in new inter-

Turn to Students, Page 2

BEARS 31, STEELERS 28



JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Fourth straight win for Bears

Bears quarterback Caleb Williams celebrates Sunday's win over the Steelers at Soldier Field. With the Steelers playing without quarterback Aaron Rodgers, the Bears' defense forced two turnovers that the offense turned into points. **Coverage in Chicago Sports**

Ukraine, allies study US plan

U.S. and Ukrainian officials said they were making progress toward ending the Russia-Ukraine war but provided scant details after discussing the American proposal. **Nation & World**

A smashing operatic concert

The world premiere of Billy Corgan's "A Night of Mellon Collie and Infinite Sadness" at Lyric Opera reinforced the songwriter's status as the biggest romantic of his generation. **Arts & Living**

Agency changes threaten elections

Midterms facing more risks without US security help

By Steve Karnowski and Julie Carr Smyth
Associated Press

MINNEAPOLIS — Since it was created in 2018, the federal government's cybersecurity agency has helped warn state and local election officials about potential threats from foreign governments, showed officials how to protect polling places from attacks and gamed out how to respond to the unexpected, such as an Election Day bomb threat or sudden disinformation campaign.

The agency was largely absent from that space for elections this month in several states, a potential preview for the 2026 midterms. Shifting priorities of the Trump administration, staffing reductions and budget cuts have many election officials concerned about how engaged the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency will be next year, when control of Congress will be at stake in those elections.

Some officials say they have begun scrambling to fill the anticipated gaps.

"We do not have a sense of

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